ASSEMBLY POLLS 2024

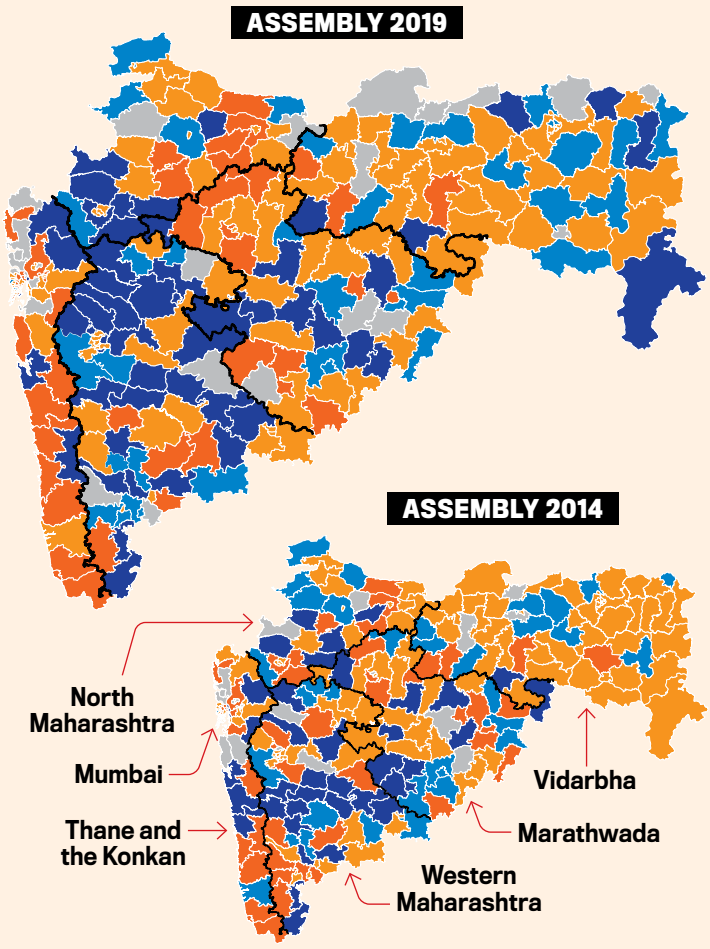
MAHARASHTRA

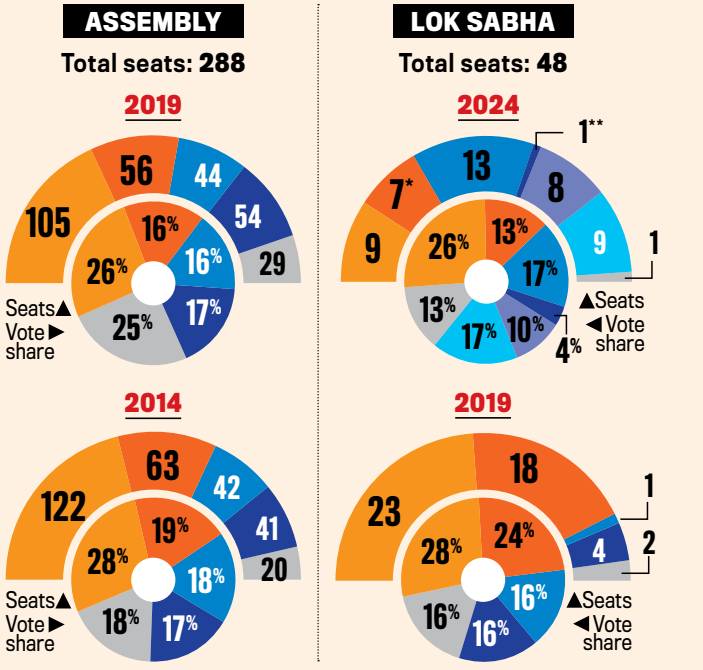
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FIRST, A REALITY CHECK. Since the Congress win in Maharashtra in 1990, the six assembly elections in the state in the past 30 years have not seen any party win a majority on its own, which means coalition governments have been the norm. The upcoming assembly election in India's commercial capital will be no different. Except that the state has seen three chief ministers and three governments in the past five years and splits in its two big regional parties, triggering unexpected political alignments and fragmenting the polity even further. Now, there are two major alliances in the fray. On one side is the ruling Mahayuti alliance, consisting of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the Chief Minister Eknath Shinde-led breakaway faction of the Shiv Sena, and the deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar's faction of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). Taking them on is the INDIA bloc's MVA or the Maha Vikas Aghadi, which has the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray), or SS(UBT), led by former CM Uddhav Thackeray, the NCP(SP) faction led by patriarch Sharad Pawar, the alliance's binding glue, and the Congress.

Each alliance and its constituents are engaged in a Maha battle for survival that will not only determine their individual fate, but also the future of the state and, in many respects, of the nation. Maharashtra is not just the state with the largest economy in the country, it also boasts the second largest number of Lok Sabha seats—48. In this year's general election, the ruling BJP's tally in the state dropped by 14 seats—from 23

PAST SPOILS





*Vote share figures have been rounded off; in 2024, *Shiv Sena (Shinde faction), **NCP (Ajit Pawar faction)*

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY